



**Baker
College**

GREATNESS
IS EARNED HERE.

PLC Programming Instructions

Programmable Logic Controllers

Brad Peirson

College of Information Technology and Engineering

Agenda

Data Types

Basic Programming Instructions

Timers and Counters

Advanced Programming Instructions

Data Manipulation Instructions

Student Learning Outcomes

1. Create programs in Ladder Logic using the following instructions in an application
2. Program PLC timers and counters

Data Types



BIT

- 1 bit
- The smallest unit of memory
- Represents discrete binary states
 - 0 (OFF/FALSE)
 - 1 (ON/TRUE)

NIBBLE

- 4 bits
- 1 binary coded decimal (BCD) digit

BYTE

- 8 Bits
- 256 unique combinations
- Typically used for ASCII characters—1 BYTE = 1 character

WORD

- 16 Bits
- Historical standard register size in PLCs (AB SLC 500/Siemens S7-300)

DWORD/LWORD

- DWORD–32 bits
- LWORD–64 bits
- Modern architecture
- Used for high precision motion/math in older systems

Sub-Bit Access

- These data types are most often used as a number
- But they are *also* just a collection of bits
- We can access the individual bit inside a word using *dot notation*
 - `Word_Var.0`, `Word_Var.7`, etc.

IEC 61131-3 Elementary Types

Type	Keyword	Bits	Signed Range	Common Industrial Usage
Boolean	BOOL	1	0 or 1 (FALSE / TRUE)	Proximity sensors, pushbuttons, coils
Short Integer	SINT	8	-128 to +127	Small part counts, status flags
Integer	INT	16	-32,768 to +32,767	Analog inputs (0-10V, 4-20mA raw counts)
Double Integer	DINT	32	-2,147,483,648 to +2,147,483,647	High-speed encoders, totalizer counts
Real (Float)	REAL	32	IEEE 754 Floating Point	Scaled engineering units (PSI, GPM, °C)

Signed Integers

- Integers can be signed (+/-) or unsigned
- The default in most PLCs is signed—unsigned is optional
- In a signed integer the first bit is the sign: 0 = +, 1 = -
- Because we lose a bit, the capacity of the number is effectively cut in half
- INT: -32,768 to 32,767
- UINT: 0 to 65,535

Floating Point Numbers

- IEEE 754 Format
- 32-bits: 1 sign, 8 exponent bits, 23 mantissa bits
- An integer is *only* whole numbers, REAL must be used if a decimal point is necessary
- *NEVER* use an equality check (`REAL_1 = 10.0`) on a REAL—floating point numbers have in-built rounding errors

Addressing Memory in PLCs

- **Direct Memory Addressing:** Logic references explicit *physical* register locations in the CPU
- **Tag-Based Addressing:** Programmer creates descriptive, symbolic names stored in a database
- IEC 61131-3 standardizes both approaches
- Older PLCs pretty exclusively direct addressed, modern PLCs mostly use tag-based databases

Direct vs. Tag-Based Syntax

AB Direct (SLC/Micrologix)

Uses fixed file letters & numbers

I:1/0–Input slot 1, bit 0

B3:0/0–Binary bit word 0, bit 3

N7:0–Integer file 7, register 0

IEC 61131-3 Direct Syntax

Uses standard prefix notation

%IX0.0–Input byte 0, bit 0

%QX0.0–Output byte 0, bit 0

%MW100–Memory word 100

Tag-Based (Logix/TIA)

Uses symbolic variable names

Conveyor_Start_PB

Tank_Level_Scaled

Hardware mapped via I/O
aliasing

Basic Programming Instructions

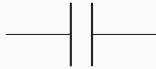
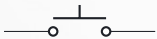
The 3 Basic Instructions

- Ladder logic doesn't care what the input *is*
- All that matters is on/off
- Remember, these were intentionally designed to look like relay contacts and coils



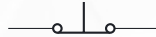
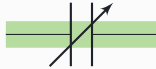
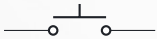
Examine if Closed (XIC)

True when the input is true (on)



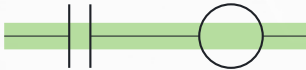
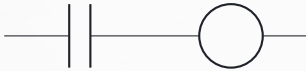
Examine if Open (XIO)

True when the input is false (off)



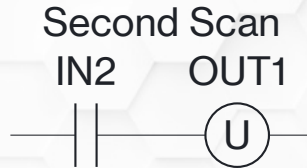
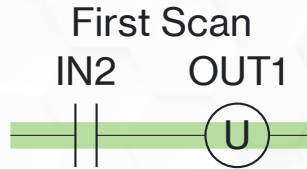
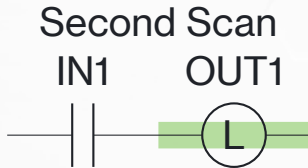
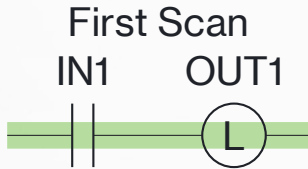
Output Energize (OTE)

True when the logic before it is true



Output Latch (OTL) and Unlatch (OTU)

Once turned on the outputs *stays on* until explicitly unlatched



Take Caution with Latches

- Be *very* careful with latches—my recommendation is to not use them as much as possible
- OTE is *volatile*—when power cycles the output is set to 0 (off)
- OTL is *NOT* volatile—if it's on when power goes out it will be on when power is restored
- This can and has caused unwanted/unsafe machine motion

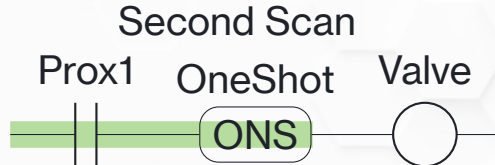
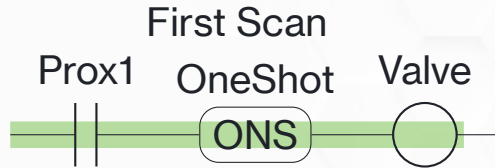
Latch/Unlatch on Key Platforms

How Key Platforms Handle Latch/Unlatch on Power Cycle

Manufacturer	Equivalent Instructions	Power Cycle Behavior	Memory Control Mechanism
Allen-Bradley (Logix5000)	OTL/OTU	Retains state across power cycles (non-volatile)	Tied directly to the instruction choice (OTL/OTU memory retention vs. OTE non-retention)
Siemens (TIA Portal)	S (Set)/ R (Reset)	Resets to 0 unless declared as Retentive	Bit/DB retain settings in tag table
Beckhoff (TwinCAT)/ CODESYS	S (Set)/ R (Reset)	Resets to 0 unless located in Retain memory	RETAIN or PERSISTENT keywords
Mitsubishi (GX Works)	SET/RST	Retains state if mapped to Latch Range	Latch (L) device memory range
Omron (Sysmac Studio)	Set/Rst	Resets to 0 unless declared as Retentive	Retain attribute checkbox on VAR

Oneshot

A oneshot is true for *one scan* while the logic before it is true—the logic has to turn false to reset it



Timers and Counters



Timers and Counters

- Timers time, counters count—but their under-the-hood structure is *very* similar
- “Timer” and “counter” refer to the *variable type*
- The timer or counter variable is then used in conjunction with a timer or counter instruction

Timer and Counter Variable Types

- Timers and counters are made up of 3 words:
 1. Word 0: Control word–used as bits, what the bits *do* vary between timers and counters
 2. Word 1: Preset (PRE)–the time/count target
 3. Word 2: Accumulated (ACC)–the current time/count

Timer Variables

- EN** Rung logic before the instruction is true
- TT** The timer is actively timing
- DN** The preset value has been reached
- PRE** The target time, in *milliseconds*
- ACC** The current timer value, in *milliseconds*

Time Base

- Some platforms use a timer time base
- $\text{Time base} \times \text{preset} = \text{total time}$
- AB RSlogix 500: time base can be 0.01s or 1s
 - Base = 0.01, Preset = 500, Time = 5s
- AB RSLogix 5000: time base is *always* 0.001s
 - Base = 0.001, Preset = 500, Time = 0.5s

Timer Variable Warning

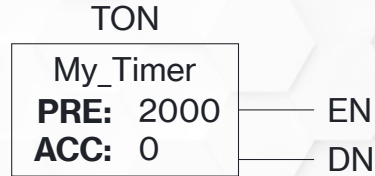
- Timer variables can only be used *once*
- Software will *allow* you to use them more than once, but you will definitely see fun and interesting behavior
- One timer variable per timer instruction

Timers and Counters

Timer On

Timer On Instruction

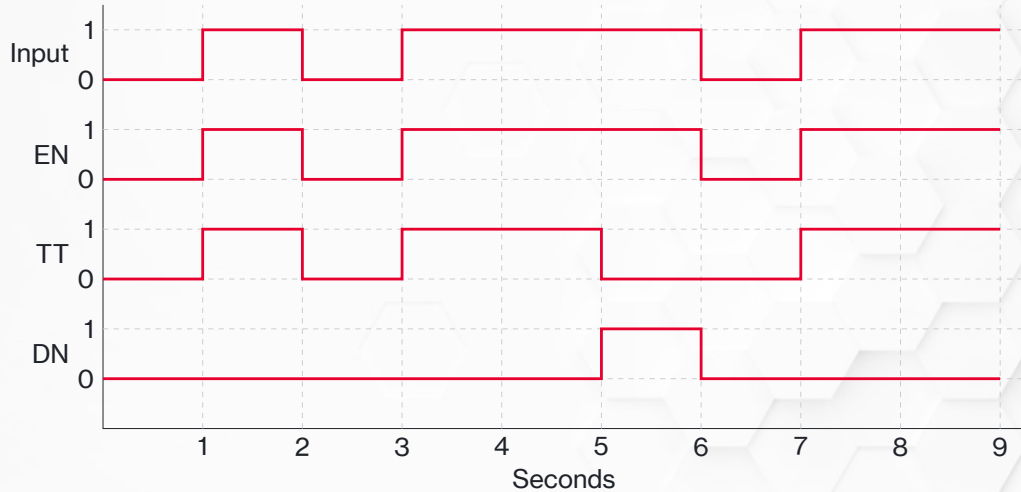
- Starts timing when the preceding logic is true
- Stops timing when the logic goes false
- ACC is cleared when the logic goes false



TON Example 1

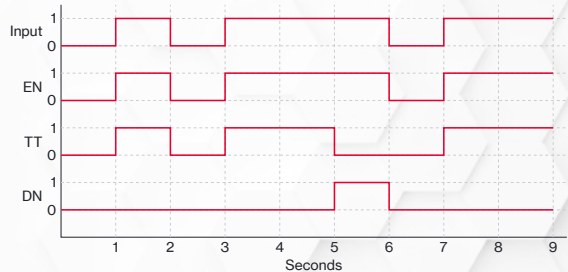


TON Timing Diagram



TON Timing Step-by-Step (1 of 7)

- At 1 second the input goes true
- The logic is true–EN turns on
- The timer starts timing–TT turns on



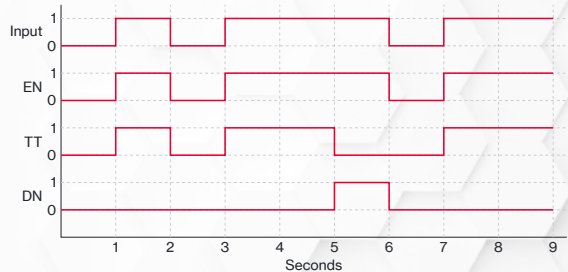
TON Timing Step-by-Step (2 of 7)



While the logic is true EN turns on, TT turns on, and ACC starts counting

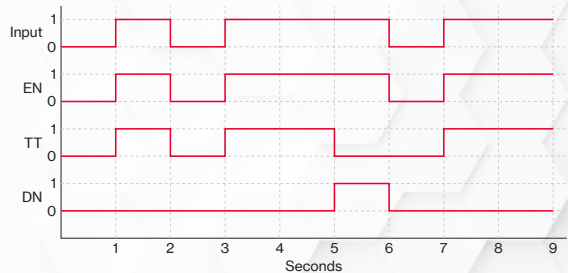
TON Timing Step-by-Step (3 of 7)

- At 2 seconds the input goes false
- The logic is false–EN turns off
- The timer stops timing–TT turns off
- The ACC is automatically cleared
- It wasn't on long enough to reach 2s, DN never turns on



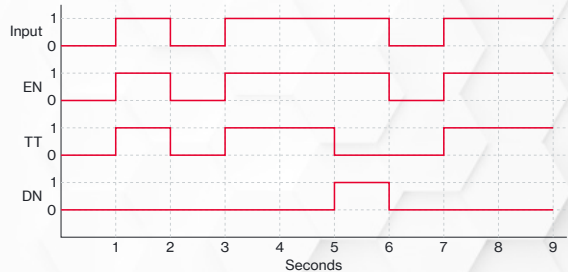
TON Timing Step-by-Step (4 of 7)

- At 3 seconds the input goes true
- The logic is true–EN turns on
- The timer starts timing–TT turns on
- ACC starts counting



TON Timing Step-by-Step (5 of 7)

- At 5 seconds the input is still on
- The logic is true—EN stays on
- $ACC \geq PRE-DN$ turns on
- ACC stops counting, holds its value
- It's not actively timing—TT turns off



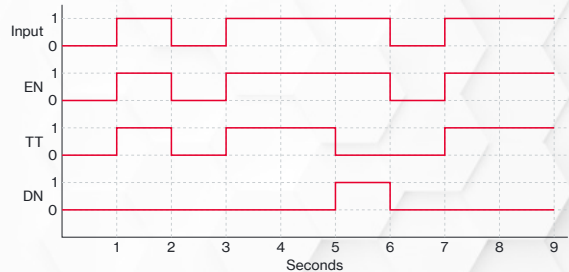
TON Timing Step-by-Step (6 of 7)



At 5 seconds $ACC \geq PRE$ so DN turns on and TT turns off

TON Timing Step-by-Step (7 of 7)

- At 6 seconds the input goes false
- The logic is false—EN turns off
- The ACC is automatically cleared
- DN turns off



ACC and DN (1 of 3)

- Note the ACC value when DN turns on—this is normal
- The TON *logic* is triggered by the PLC scan
- The TON *timing* happens in a separate processor thread
- The scan checks in every pass to compare the new ACC to PRE

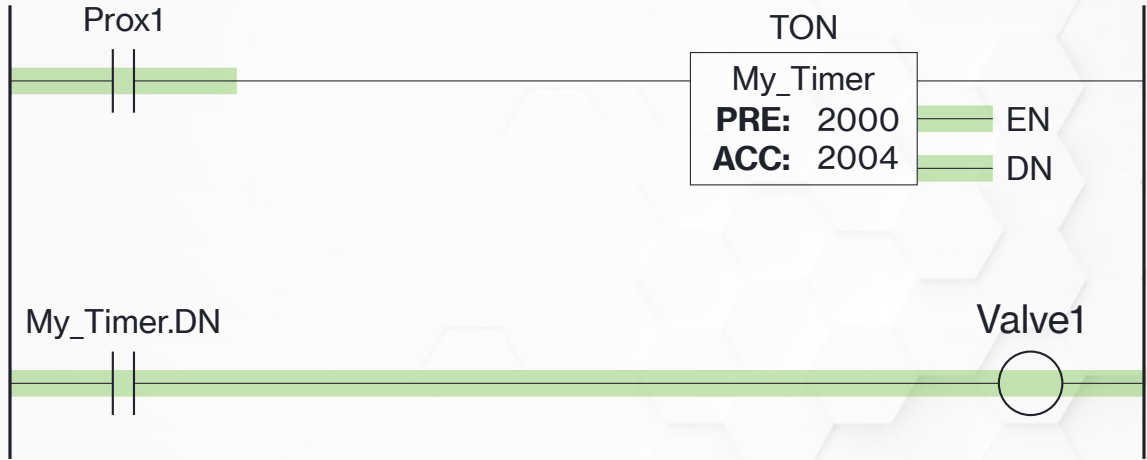


ACC and DN (2 of 3)

- The ACC will *always* be slightly bigger than PRE when the timer finishes
- You *cannot* do an equal comparison (ACC=PRE) because it's *never* true
- That's what DN is for



ACC and DN (3 of 3)



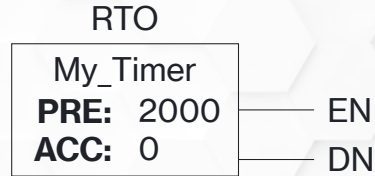
Use DN to trigger logic that has to happen when the timer finishes, *not* an equal comparison

Timers and Counters

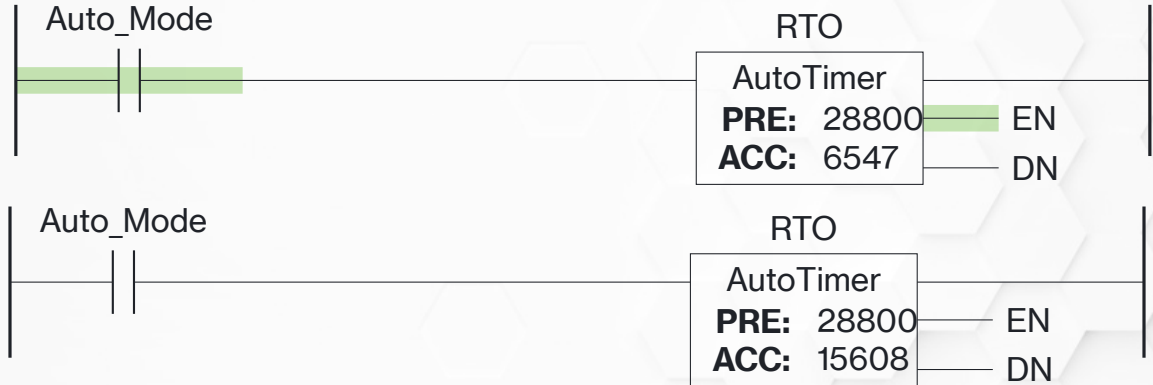
Retentive Timer On

Retentive Timer On (RTO)

- RTO works exactly like TON with *one* difference
- ACC *does not* clear when the input goes false
- ACC must be explicitly cleared with a RES instruction



RTO Example (1 of 3)



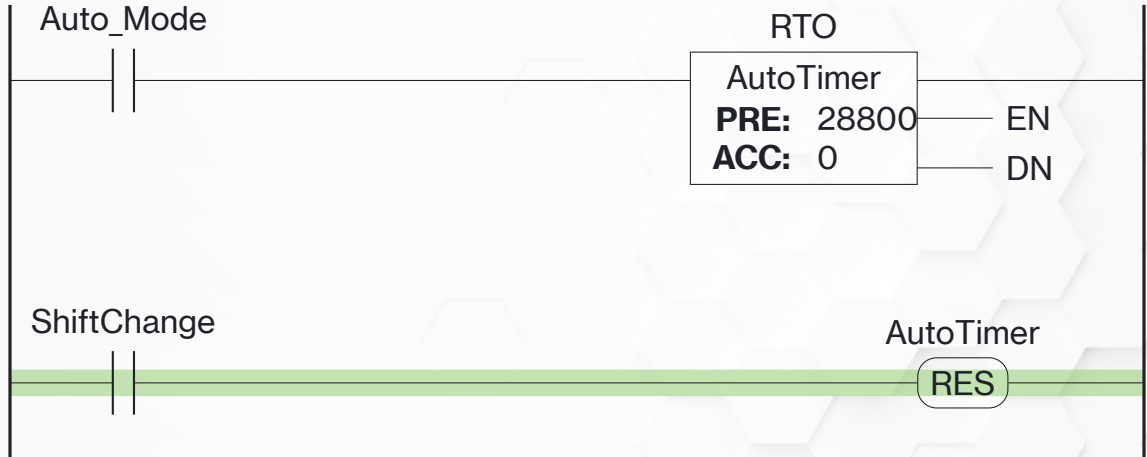
Top: the RTO times as normal when the logic is true. Bottom: When the logic false, the RTO stops timing but retains the ACC.

RTO Example (3 of 3)



When PRE is reached DN turns on

RTO Example (3 of 3)



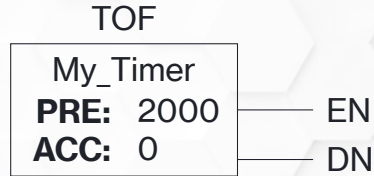
The ACC and DN will *stay on* until a RES instruction is used on the timer

Timers and Counters

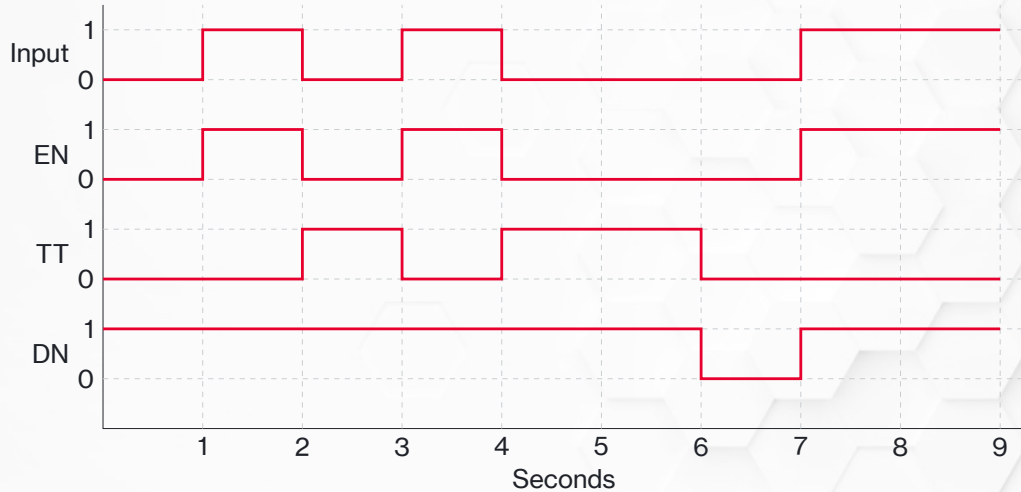
Timer Off

Timer Off Instruction

- Used to keep things running *after* the timer finishes (cooling fans)
- DN is on most of the time, it turns *off* when the timer finishes

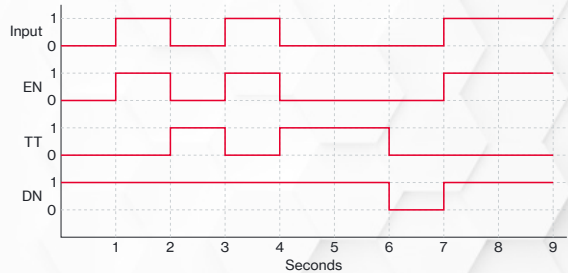


TOF Timing Diagram



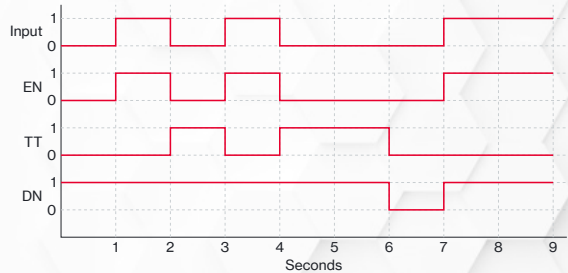
TOF Timing Step-by-Step (1 of 7)

- At 0s the input it off
- DN is *already* on



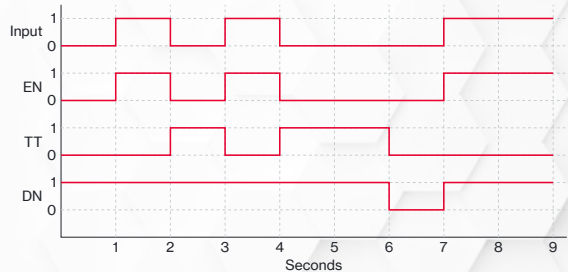
TOF Timing Step-by-Step (2 of 7)

- At 1s the input turns on
- EN turns on
- DN is *still* on



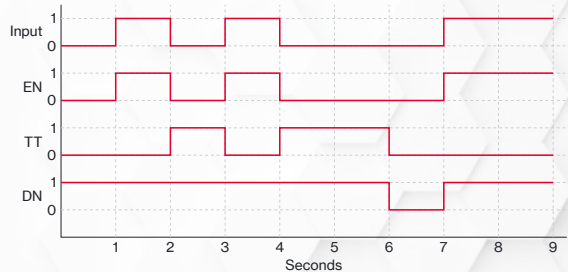
TOF Timing Step-by-Step (3 of 7)

- At 2s the input turns off
- EN turns off
- TT turns on
- The timer starts timing as soon as the input turns off



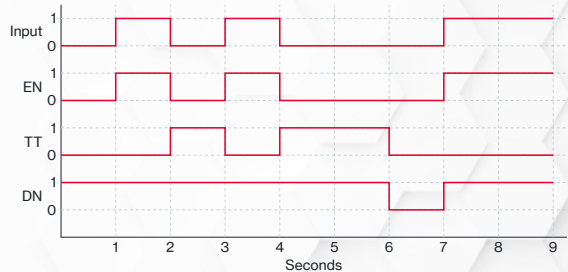
TOF Timing Step-by-Step (4 of 7)

- At 3s the input turns on
- EN turns on
- TT turns off
- The timer preset hasn't been met, nothing happens with DN



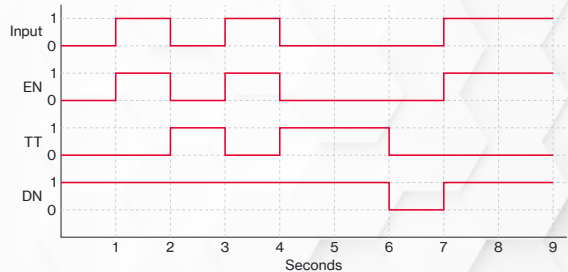
TOF Timing Step-by-Step (5 of 7)

- At 4s the input turns off
- EN turns off
- TT turns on
- The timer starts timing as soon as the input turns off



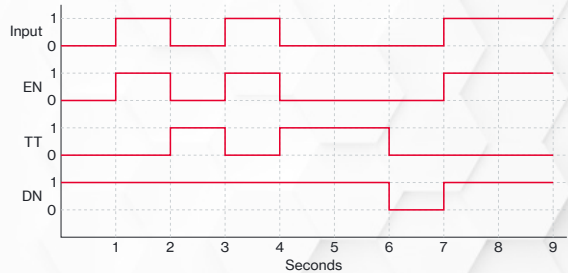
TOF Timing Step-by-Step (6 of 7)

- At 6s we hit the preset
- TT turns off—it's not actively timing anymore
- DN turns *off*

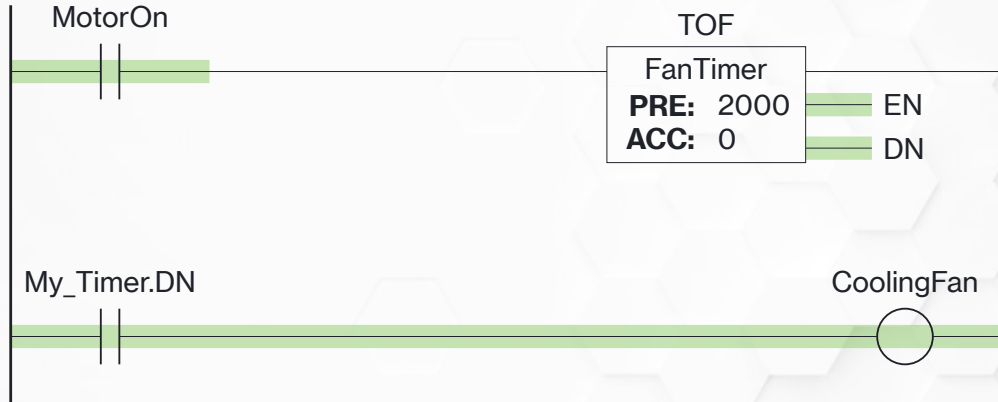


TOF Timing Step-by-Step (7 of 7)

- At 7s the input turns on
- EN turns on
- DN turns *on*

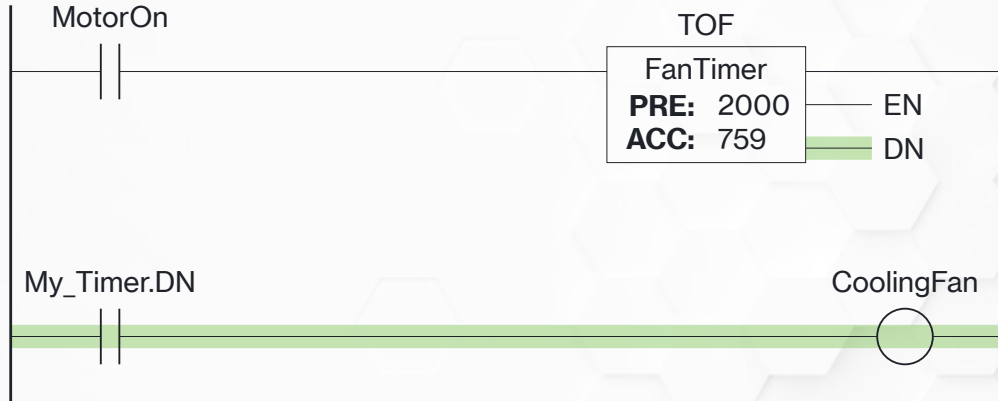


TOF Example (1 of 3)



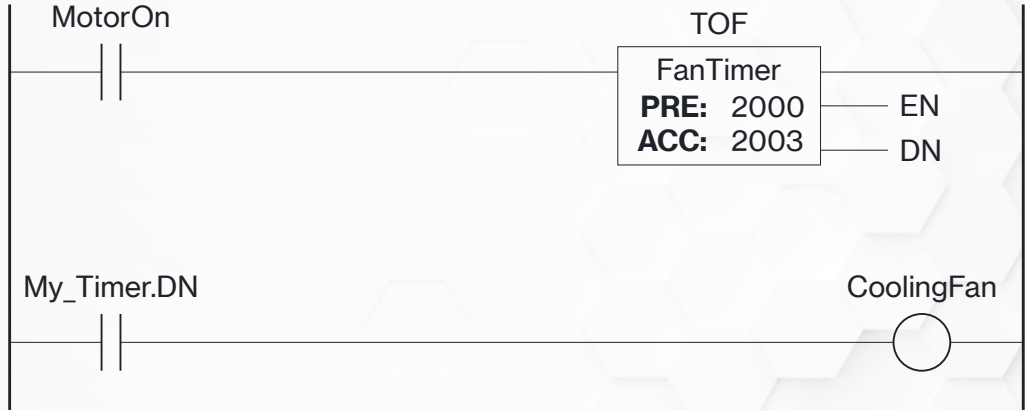
While the input is on, DN remains on and timer *is not* timing

TOF Example (2 of 3)



As soon as the input drops out the timer starts timing—EN drops, but DN stays on

TOF Example (3 of 3)



When we hit PRE, DN drops out

Timers and Counters

Counters

Counter Variables

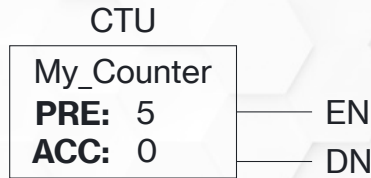
- CU** The logic before the CTU instruction is true
- CD** The logic before the CTD instruction is true
- DN** The preset value has been reached
- OV** The ACC has exceeded the DINT limit of 2,147,483,647
- UN** The ACC has exceed the DINT limit of -2,147,483,648
- PRE** The target count
- ACC** The current count

Counter Usage

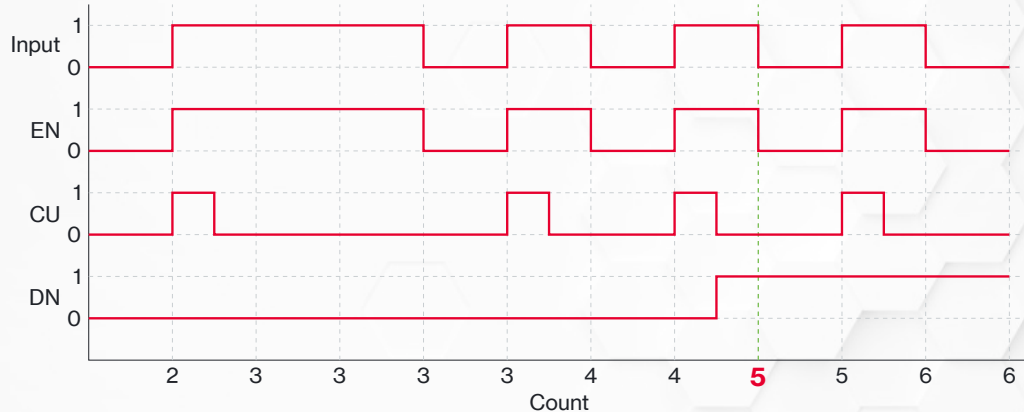
- Unlike timer variables, counter variables can be used *twice*
- Once for a count up (CTU) and once for a count down (CTD)
- Recommendation: put the CTU and CTD *very* close to one another—makes it easier to troubleshoot

Count Up (CTU)

- Adds one to the count when the preceding logic is true
- *ONLY* adds one—the logic must go false in order to count again
- If the counter variable needs to be cleared, must use a RES instruction

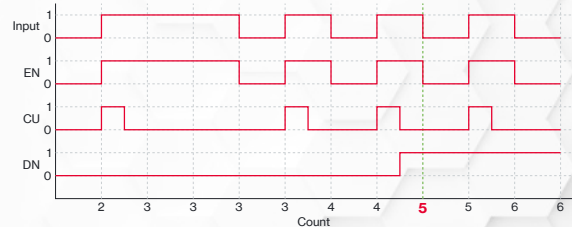


CTU Timing Diagram



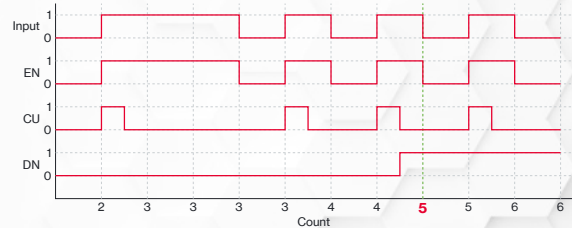
CTU Step-by-Step (1 of 4)

- The input becomes true
- EN turns on
- CU turns on—it only stays on long enough for the count to happen
- The ACC is incremented by 1
- As long as the input stays on CU never pulses, ACC stays where it is



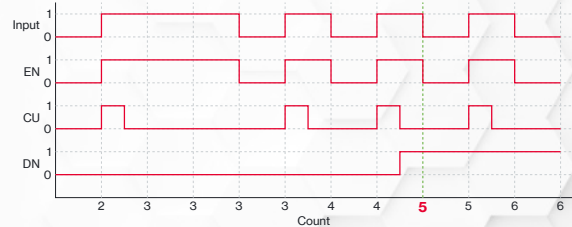
CTU Step-by-Step (2 of 4)

- After several input pulses
ACC = PRE
- DN energizes



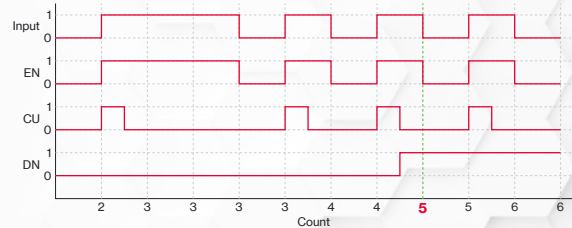
CTU Step-by-Step (3 of 4)

- If left alone, the counter will keep counting every input pulse
- DN stays on as long as $ACC \geq PRE$

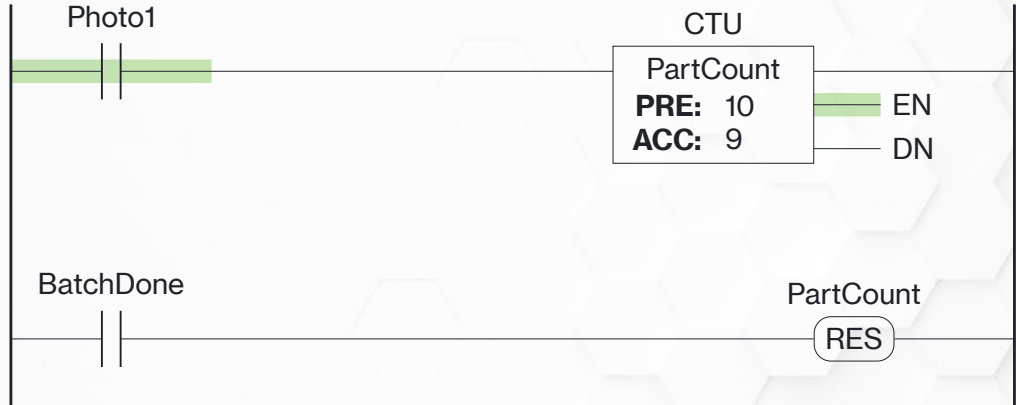


CTU Step-by-Step (4 of 4)

- Eventually the ACC will exceed 2,147,483,647 (DINT limit)
- At that point ACC will roll over to read -2,147,483,648 and count up from there
- DN will stay on
- OV will turn on

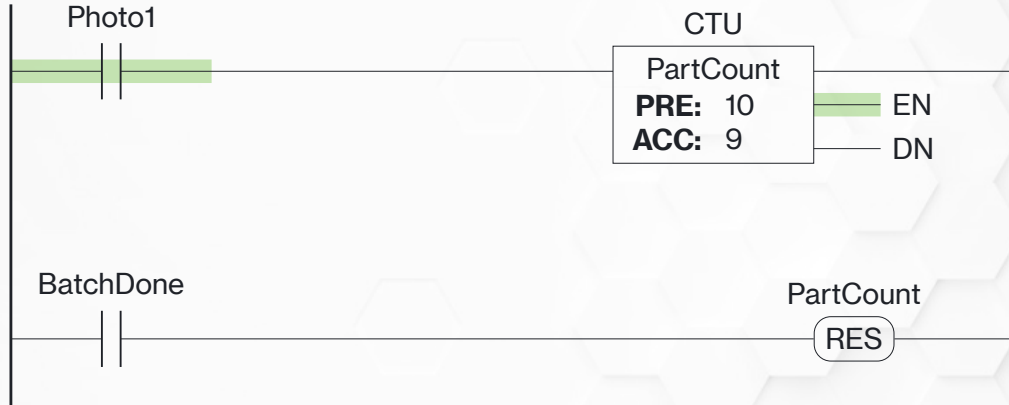


CTU Example 1 (1 of 7)



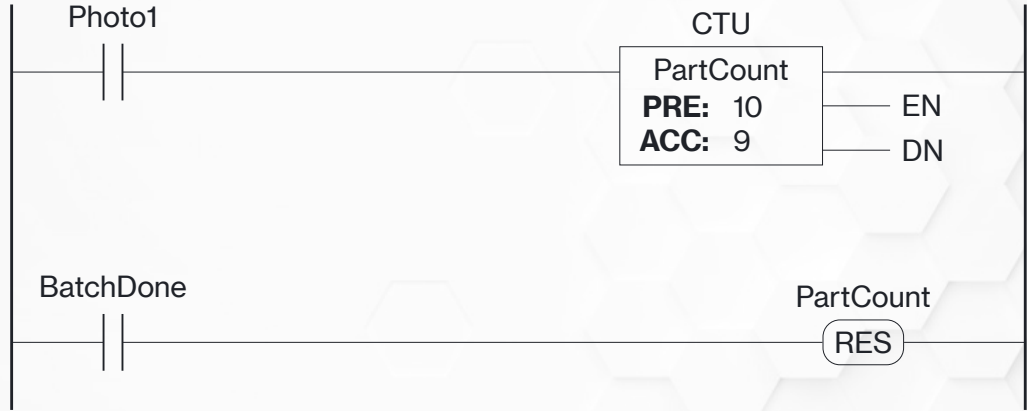
The input turns on, EN turns on, and the count increments by one

CTU Example 1 (2 of 7)



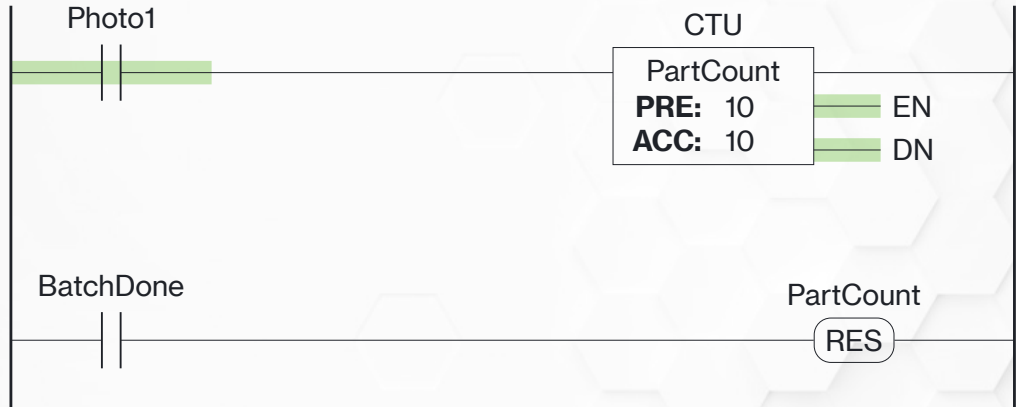
As long as the input *stays* on, EN stays on but ACC stays where it is

CTU Example 1 (3 of 7)



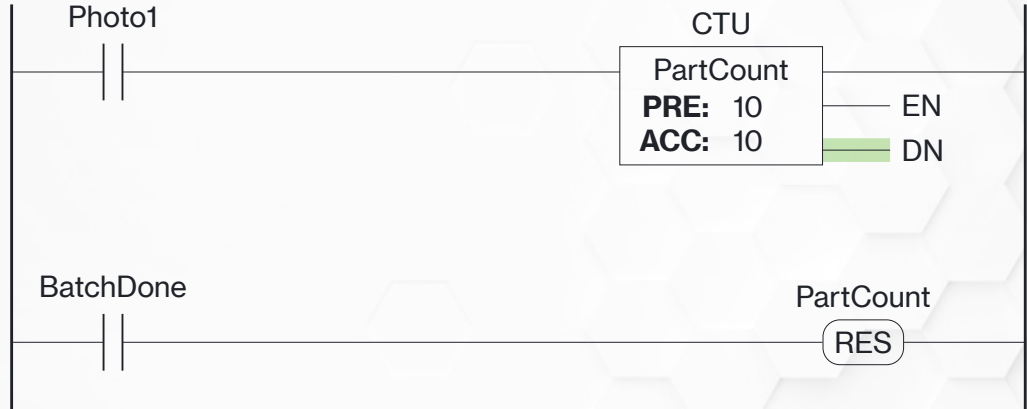
When the input turns off, EN turns off

CTU Example 1 (4 of 7)



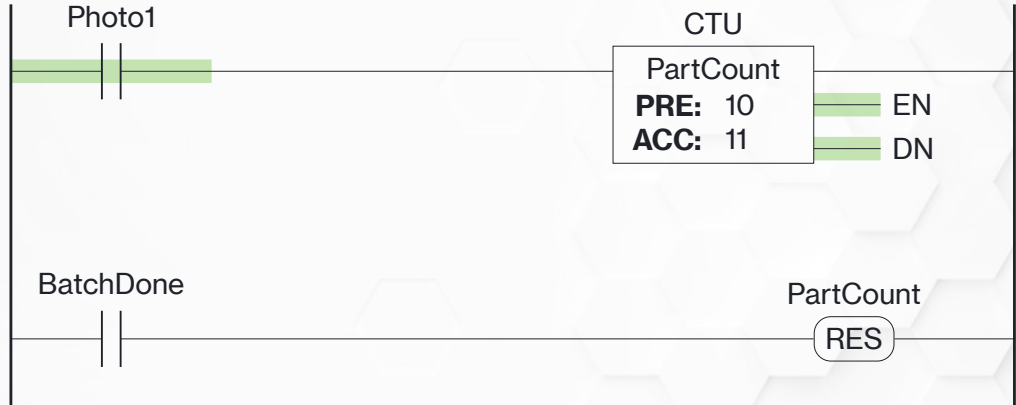
When the input turns on again, EN turns on and ACC increments. Because $ACC = PRE$, DN also turns on.

CTU Example 1 (5 of 7)



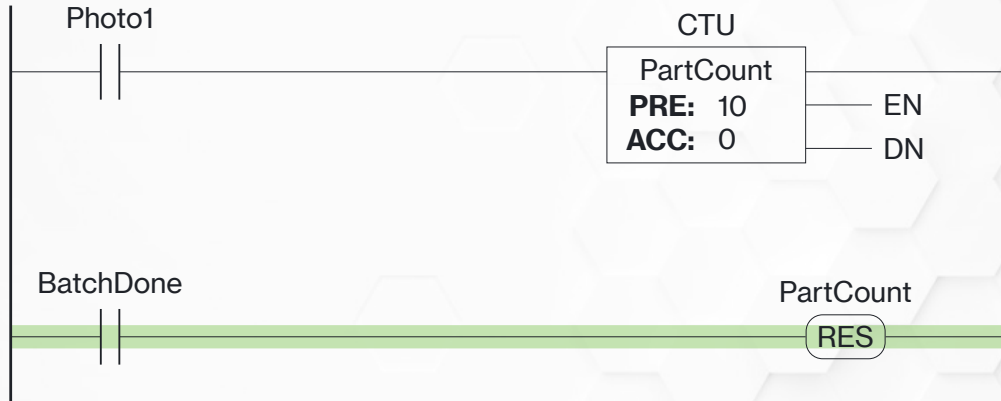
When the input drops out, so does EN. But DN stays on.

CTU Example 1 (6 of 7)



ACC will keep incrementing with each new input pulse, and DN will stay on

CTU Example 1 (7 of 7)



A RES instruction can be used on the counter variable to reset the ACC back to 0

Advanced Programming Instructions

Data Manipulation Instructions



Copyright Notice



PLC Programming Instructions©2026 by Brad Peirson is licensed under **CC BY-NC-SA 4.0**. To view a copy of this license, visit <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/4.0/>